HVAC · $3M–$5M EBITDA · SELL-SIDE

Same metro. Same revenue. Same year.

Seller A · tax returns & a tired handshake	3.1×
Seller B · data room & 18 months of prep	7.2×

GAP ON $4M EBITDA

$16.4M

Paul Baker

Founder, smbx.ai · 20+ years in M&A

SWIPE ›

THE 3.1× SELLER

He brought tax returns and a tired handshake.

Concentration	**40% in 2 contracts**
Management	**Founder runs every bid**
Financials	**Tax-basis, no QofE**
PE interest	**3 firms. All passed.**
Outcome	**Strategic low-ball, accepted**

THE 7.2× SELLER

He brought a data room and 18 months of preparation.

Concentration	**35% → 12%**
Management	**VP Ops, Sales Dir, Svc Mgr**
Owner role	**9 months out of meetings**
Sell-side QofE	**$1.2M documented add-backs**

Result: 7.2× $28.8M close

SAME EARNINGS. DIFFERENT OUTCOME.

$4M EBITDA, two prices.

SALE PRICE ON $4M EBITDA

Seller A · 3.1×	**$12.4M**
Seller B · 7.2×	**$28.8M**

GAP **$16.4M**

Same industry. Same metro. Same year. One ran a process; one took an offer.

RUN A BASELINE

Find what a buyer would flag — before they do.

Eighteen months of prep is what separates 3× from 7×. The first step is knowing what's in your data room before the buyer asks for it.

FREE · 12 MINUTES

Run a Baseline™ on your business.

Start at smbx.ai ›

No account required · Your data stays yours